

1270

DEATH OF SAINT LOUIS

The reign of Louis IX (1226–70) was a golden age for France, but his crusading ventures proved disastrous. Twenty years after a failed invasion of Egypt in 1250, he led an attack on the Hafsids in North Africa. Landing in Tunisia, he died of disease. He was canonized in 1297.



△ Death of Louis IX

1270

1270 Yekuno Amlak founds the Solomonic dynasty that will rule in Ethiopia until 1974

1271 Kublai Khan becomes Chinese emperor, founding the Yuan dynasty



△ Mongol horse archer

1279

FALL OF THE SOUTHERN SONG

By 1234, the Mongols controlled northern China but the rich and populous south remained under the rule of the Song dynasty. Led by Kublai Khan from 1260, the Mongols attacked the Song, fielding a vast army and creating a navy to fight on rivers. After epic battles, the southern capital Hangzhou fell in 1276 and by 1279 all of China was under Mongol rule. Pursued as a fugitive, the last Song emperor, seven-year-old Zhao Bing, was drowned during a naval battle.

1280 GUNPOWDER WEAPONS

Gunpowder was used in Chinese warfare from the 11th century and perhaps even earlier. Simple bombs and firecrackers evolved into flamethrowers and tubes firing projectiles. It was probably during the conflict between the Mongols and the Song in the late 13th century that guns were first widely used, in the form of metal-barrelled hand cannons. These primitive devices proved quite effective and, within half a century, imitations of the Chinese guns were being deployed in wars in Europe.



△ Yuan dynasty
Chinese hand cannon

